Cup soccer has an edge. The Champions League starts to get much more exciting, for the supporters and for the players, at the knockout stage. In 1999, we were drawn against Inter Milan in the quarter-finals. It would have been a big game anyway but, beforehand, all the hype was about the fact that it would be the first meeting between David Beckham and Diego Simeone, who played his club soccer for Inter, since the World Cup and Saint-Etienne. Never mind who was going to win, half the pre-match build-up seemed to be about who would and who wouldn't be shaking a particular opponent's hand before kick-off at Old Trafford.

As far as I was concerned, all that really mattered was the game. The only thing I made up my mind about in advance was that I'd try to get Simeone's shirt afterwards. It's framed at home now, along with all the others from great players I've competed against during my career. I had something else on my mind, too, that evening: the one thing in the world that might have seemed more important than the soccer match I was getting ready to play. Victoria was due to give birth to our baby any day. I was sitting in the players' lounge at Old Trafford, waiting to go into our team meeting, when the cell phone rang. Victoria's number came up on the screen. *This is it. It's happening.* It turned out Victoria had called to tell me she'd had a twinge but that things were okay. She was fine and wished me good luck and I went into the meeting with a clear head.

Before Champions League games, you go along the line of opposition players before kick-off, shaking hands. I still remember the explosion of flashbulbs that went off at the moment Simeone and I came face to face. During the match itself, we didn't see all that much of each other, save for a moment when we almost collided and he caught my ankle. I'll never know whether he meant it or not. The important thing was I didn't react. It turned into a great night for us. In the first half, I sent in two crosses that Dwight Yorke put away and the final score was 2–0. Inter were a really difficult team to play against and that result was just right. I was a happy man by the time I spoke to Victoria on the phone again. She laughed when I told her I'd got Simeone's shirt and that he'd given me a peck on the cheek as we came off the field at the end. We agreed I'd head down to London after training the following day.

That win, a good night's sleep and a stretch in the morning—it suddenly felt like I was starting to move on from the sending off and everything that had come with it. Whether anybody else would, of course, wasn't up to me. It wouldn't be until the summer of 2002 that I'd be able, finally, to put what happened in Saint-Etienne behind me forever. But having played well against